with his bail-changing tricks and all the theatre he has learned to switch on at his will. It's the most glorious, unbelievable way to go. With the Oval already full to the last seat, we walk out to bat together on the first morning to a guard of honour from the Australians. I'm the first person he tells that he is retiring and just like Cooky, he says he wants to test the words in front of me to make sure it feels right. And still, I watch him leave and do not think of my own legacy moment or even that maybe I should do. I just think that I will play until I'm stopped. I will never end my own career for England.

It's an Ashes series that doesn't click personally, my best moment probably coming at the Major League Baseball London Series at the London Stadium where I zing a first pitch twice as hard as Nathan Lyon's before the St. Louis Cardinals take on the Chicago Cubs. But I give myself a talking to and get myself into the best shape I have ever been in my life for the India tour. I feel as strong as I've ever been, as enthusiastic about playing for England as ever, and at the foot of the Himalayas in Dharamshala, become the first fast bowler ever to take 700 Test wickets. My dad is there to see it. I look up at the mountains as I leave the ground, unaware I will soon be walking into that Manchester hotel to be told I only have one game left. If I had the chance, I would have climbed that mountain again, the same way I did leaving Burnley, just to feel that thrill of belonging and the buzz of giving my service to something bigger than I could ever be.